were constructed under the rule of the Vakatakas, close allies of the Guptas. The paintings are obviously stylized but they give us a sense of what Indians of this period idealized. One of the things that strikes me is that most of the people in the paintings are very dark-skinned. It appears that ancient Indians had a preference for dark skin. This is supported by a lot of other evidence. For instance, the epitome of male handsomeness in the Hindu tradition is Krishna who is clearly dark. His name literally means 'The Dark One' (his depiction as 'blue-skinned' is merely a medieval artistic innovation). Similarly, the beautiful Draupadi, the common wife of the Pandava brothers in the Mahabharata, is also described as being very dark.

This preference for dark skin appears to have survived well into the medieval period. Indeed, Marco Polo specifically mentions this in his comments about India: 'For I assure you that the darkest man is here the most highly esteemed and considered better than others who are not so dark. Let me add that in very truth these people portray and depict their gods and their idols black and their devils white as snow.'[18] One only needs to look at the idol of Lord Jagannath in Puri to see what Polo meant.

It is unclear when and why this preference switched, but it shows that the traditional Indian aesthetic was very different from how we now perceive it. This may be somewhat inconvenient to those who sell skin-whitening creams to modern Indian consumers. Of course, Indians are not the only ones subject to changing tastes. Just five generations ago, Europeans considered pale white skin so attractive that Victorian women were willing to risk poisoning by using an arsenic-based compound to whiten their skin. Today, their descendants risk skin cancer from too much sun-bathing. Basically, you cannot win.

BATHING IN HOLY WATERS

By the first half of the sixth century, the Gupta Empire began to gradually crumble in the face of internal frictions and repeated attacks by Hunas (White Huns) from the North West. Taxila, the famous centre of learning